

Hippocrates (see box), he believed the “humoral imbalance” could be located in a single organ. To treat such problems, he used herbs. He cataloged more than 300 plants with medicinal properties and developed a system known as the “Galenic degrees” to describe their potency. He also practiced bloodletting (or “breathing a vein”), believing that fever and headaches came from too much “sanguine humor.”

Galen is thought to have lived to the age of 87. His ideas formed the cornerstone of medical thinking for centuries.

“The working body is not understandable **without knowledge of its structure.**”

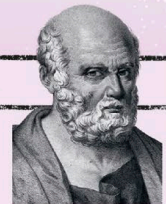
Galen



It was illegal to dissect human bodies in Rome, so Galen had to learn what he could from dissecting apes. This caused him to make a few mistakes about human anatomy and the workings of the body.

HIPPOCRATES

Known as the “Great Physician,” Hippocrates was the first physician to develop a rational system for the treatment of disease.



Unlike his contemporaries, Hippocrates (c.460–370 BCE) did not believe that diseases had supernatural causes. He thought that ill health resulted from imbalances in the body’s four humors and that the physician’s role was to restore that balance. He founded a medical school on his native island of Kos, where new students swore an oath to maintain high ethical standards, including the principles of confidentiality (to keep a patient’s illness private) and nonmaleficence (to ensure that a patient is never harmed). Swearing the “Hippocratic oath” is still common practice in many countries.